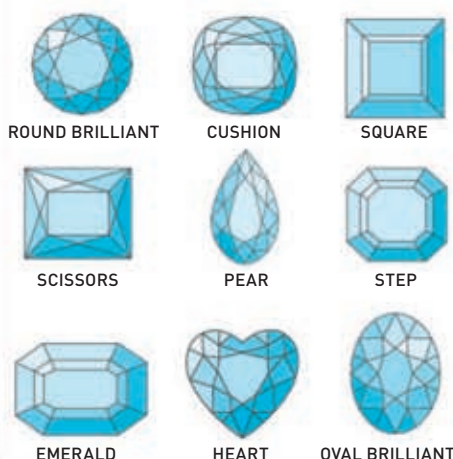


Gems

A gemstone, or gem, is a mineral that has been polished and shaped by a skilled craftsman in order to enhance its beauty. The most highly prized gems are hard-wearing and rare. There are more than 5,000 known minerals on Earth, but fewer than 100 are used as gemstones.

GEM SHAPES

Gemstones can be shaped in many ways. Some shapes, or "cuts", are very popular for rings, especially diamond rings. More than three-quarters of all diamonds today are cut into the "round brilliant" shape.



BIRTHSTONES

Some gemstones are traditionally associated with certain months of the year. It is believed to be lucky to wear the gem for your birth month.

JANUARY	FEBRUARY	MARCH	APRIL
			
GARNET	AMETHYST	AQUAMARINE	DIAMOND
MAY	JUNE	JULY	AUGUST
			
EMERALD	PEARL	RUBY	PERIDOT
SEPTEMBER	OCTOBER	NOVEMBER	DECEMBER
			
SAPPHIRE	TOURMALINE	TOPAZ	TURQUOISE

PRECIOUS STONES

Traditionally, gems such as opal, emerald, sapphire, ruby, and diamond were named "precious" stones. This was because their rarity made them the most valuable. Today, gems are valued in several different ways. The term "precious" is outdated, although jewellers still find it useful.



SEMI-PRECIOUS STONES

Gems found in large quantities were once said to be "semi-precious" and had a lower value than rare stones. However, a gem's beauty and popularity are now also considered part of its value. Some "semi-precious" stones sell for more money than "precious" ones.



QUARTZ GEMS

Quartz is one of the most common and varied minerals on Earth. It comes in an amazing number of colours and intricate patterns.

